NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥10

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥9

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ J 9 7
♥ A 5
♦ A K J 10 3
♣ A K 6

♠ 8 5 2
♥ J 10 4
♦ 9 6 2
♣ Q 10 9 4



♠ K Q 10 4
♥ 9 8 6 2
♦ 5 4
♣ 8 5 3

♠ A 6 3
♥ K Q 7 3
♦ Q 8 7
♣ J 7 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	4NT
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♠K

Because of his 3-4-3-3 distribution, partner chose not to look for a ♥ fit. If he had opted for Stayman the contract would have turned out the same. The 4NT response is quantitative, inviting you to bid 6NT if you have a maximum.

You do. 6NT.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♠K. You will have to make an early decision on whether to hold up or not.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 5 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 11

Only one more winner is needed. You should play a low ♠ from dummy in the hope that East will lead the suit again, giving you a trick with your ♠J (you know East holds ♠Q). In fact, you should even give him some incentive to play another ♠ by dropping your ♠9, pretending to hold just the ♠ J 9. But East noticed his partner's discouraging ♠2 and switched to the ♣8.

You try the ♣J but West plays the ♣Q and you have to win with your ♣K.

Your chances for success are slipping away and you are down to your last hope. Your ♠J is a threat that only East can guard against. If East also is the defender with long ♥s then he would also have to guard dummy's fourth ♥. In that case you could squeeze him. But there is one important play you must make for the squeeze to function.

You must play dummy's ♠A to unblock so your ♠J can be the threat you need. Then play the ♥A, ♣A and 5 ♦ winners.

If East has thrown the ♠Q you win your ♠J and dummy's two high ♥s. But since he probably held onto the ♠Q you just play a ♥ to dummy and hope all three ♥s are winners.

Since East had to guard both the ♥s and your ♠J, he was unable to do both, and the squeeze worked.

You were lucky it wasn't West with the 4 ♥s.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 10 5 ♥ A K 6 5 ♦ J 10 3 ♣ Q J 9 5	
♠ J 9 8 6 2 ♥ Q 2 ♦ A Q ♣ 8 7 4 3		♠ A K Q 4 ♥ J 8 3 ♦ 9 8 ♣ A K 6 2
	♠ 7 3 ♥ 10 9 7 4 ♦ K 7 6 5 4 2 ♣ 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥10

Partner expects you to bid 2♠.

But your hand has suddenly increased in value - with the known ♠ fit you add another point for your doubleton and you have 18 points. So you jump to 3♠; this is called a Super-Accept. But so what. Partner just bids the game anyway.

East plays 4♠. South leads the ♥10. North plays the ♥K, then ♥A, then ♥5.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 5

You need to eliminate two losers. If South has the ♦K a finesse will save one loser. If ♣s split 3-2 that will eliminate one loser. And of course your ♥J is ready to provide an immediate discard.

So what are you going to discard right now on that ♥J? It looks obvious to discard the ♦Q; then if the ♣s do split 3-2 (68% chance) you will be home free, losing only two ♥s and one♣.

Throwing the ♦Q is a bad idea. And basically unnecessary. If the ♣s are splitting 3-2 you don't need to keep a fourth ♣ in both hands. So discard a small ♣ from dummy and keep the ♦Q just in case the ♣s turn out 4-1 and you have to fall back on the ♦ finesse.

Looking at all four hands you can see why you needed to keep the ♦Q.

After you pull trumps you play the top two ♣s and discover (too late) that you cannot set up a ♣ winner.

But what if the ♦K was actually with North, and the ♣s were splitting 3-2 all the time?

In this scenario it is still ok to discard a small ♣ from dummy.

You pull trumps first, then play two top ♣s. When both defenders follow you give up a ♣. South wins and plays a ♦, but you go up with dummy's ♦A, enter your hand with a trump and **NOW** discard that ♦Q on your good ♣.

Board 3
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ K J 4 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A 7 4 2 ♣ Q 10 6 2	
♠ 8 7 5 3 ♥ 9 6 ♦ Q J 8 5 ♣ A 7 5		♠ A 6 2 ♥ Q J 10 8 4 3 ♦ 9 3 ♣ 8 4
	♠ Q 10 9 ♥ A K 2 ♦ K 10 6 ♣ K J 9 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♥	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥9

You should be sure you and partner are on the same page with this bid. A 2NT overcall over a Weak-2 opener shows the same hand as a 1NT overcall over a 1 of a suit opener. In other words, 15-18 points, and at least 1 (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit.

Partner, who is on the same page, bids 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥9. As expected, West leads his partner's ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

You need 5 more winners. This is important to keep in mind.

You can establish at most 1 winner in ♦s, 2 in ♠s, and 3 in ♣s. Since you must work on both ♠s and ♣s, you don't need to try for anything extra in ♦s.

If East has both black Aces you will go down, but you know that he cannot have two outside Aces with a 6-card ♥ suit headed by the Q J and still open with a weak 2-bid. So West must have at least one of the black Aces.

If you could guess which Ace East holds you could work on that suit first. He would win it, then get his ♥s established, but wouldn't be able to get back in to cash them.

But better than guessing, you should just holdup on the first ♥ trick and win the next one. Then it won't matter which Ace you knock out first because West will not have a ♥ to play in either case.

If you win the first trick and then play ♠s, you will be lucky. East will have to take his ♠A and then establish his ♥s. And when West takes the ♣A he won't have a ♥ to play.

If you win the first trick and then play ♣s, you will be unlucky. West will take his ♣A and play his last ♥. Then when East takes the ♠A he will set you with ♥ tricks.

If you hold up on first trick luck won't come into it. It will no longer matter which black suit you establish first.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K 8 2 ♥ Q J 10 9 6 ♦ K 9 5 2 ♣ A	
♠ A 7 4 ♥ A K 5 ♦ A 6 3 ♣ J 8 5 2	N W E S	♠ Q 6 3 ♥ 8 4 2 ♦ Q 8 ♣ K Q 10 9 6
	♠ J 10 9 5 ♥ 7 3 ♦ J 10 7 4 ♣ 7 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	2♥	3♣	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♥Q

After the overcall of your partner's opening 1NT you must make a quick decision with this type of hand:Force to game or settle for partscore. Using lebensohl, a suit bid at the 3-level shows a 5-card or longer suit and is game forcing. You go for it by bidding 3♣ (not Stayman) and partner says 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♥Q. You must make an immediate decision whether to hold up or not.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

Of course the ♣ suit will produce 4 winners so you need just one more in ♠s or ♦s.

First the question of holding up or not. The reason for a hold-up play is to be sure that when South gains the lead he has no ♥s remaining. But in this Deal you can place most of the strength with North so you don't need to hold up. And, in fact, there is a good reason why you shouldn't.

Win the first trick with your ♥K and immediately play a ♣, taken by North's ♣A. He plays the ♥J which you win with your ♥A. South followed suit to the second ♥!

North has 3 ♥ winners in his hand. There is a good chance that he has the ♠K and ♦K as well. So if you play either of those suits, leading toward the Queen, North will jump up with his King and put you down 1. So instead, play a ♣ winner, and when North shows out, play your last ♥! North will smile as he takes his three ♥ winners but then he will frown when he realizes he must lead away from one of his Kings! You, of course, will jump up with dummy's Queen of that suit for your ninth trick.

We learn at bridge that you should lead toward high cards to try to establish them. For example, in this Deal leading toward the ♠Q would establish a winner as long as North held the ♠K. Unfortunately you would be giving up the setting trick as you established the winner.

Always keep in the back of your mind the possibility of an elimination play. In this Deal that meant you needed to refuse the hold-up because you would need the third ♥ to throw North in with.